

Statement of Daniel P. McElhatton, Esquire

Pennsylvania House of Representatives
State Government Committee
Public Hearing on Congressional Redistricting October 20, 2021 9:00 a.m.
American Heritage Federal Credit Union
Community Room
2060 RedLion Road
Philadelphia, PA 19115

Chairman Grove and members of the Committee. My name is Daniel P. McElhatton and I appreciate the opportunity to appear before you today and present testimony on the issue of the Congressional Redistricting as a result of the 2020 census. As a result of this census it appears that the Commonwealth of Pennsylvania will lose one seat in the United States House of Representatives and consequently it is up to the Pennsylvania House of Representatives to minimize the negative impact of that loss of representation.

I bring to my testimony the experience of being a member of the Board of Directors of the Greater Northeast Philadelphia Chamber of Commerce and a former Chair of that Board. Today, however, my testimony is not submitted on behalf of the Chamber but on my own behalf.

I have had direct experience in the process of redistricting when I served as an elected member of the City Council of Philadelphia. Elected to represent the 7th Council District in 1991. I was intimately involved in the redistricting efforts after the 1990 census. The District I represented included approximately 170,000 residents and these council districts were as large as many of the cities in the Commonwealth. The district for which I was elected was different from the one that I would be required to run in for reelection. This shifting of population and redrawing of neighboring lines had a significant negative impact on my district. I was able to see the impact on the neighborhoods and the community groups when these folks were shifted from some long standing relationships to new and challenging relationships.

I speak today to recommend that as you consider your responsibilities to draw new boundaries that you keep in mind the fact that Philadelphia is a separate political entity and dividing that entity among legislative districts has negative impacts. In particular, if significant portions of the Northeast Philadelphia community are moved into a Bucks County District this would dilute the electoral power of what has heretofore been a rather homogeneous electorate.

The Far Northeast has traditionally been a strong Republican area and has operated as a balance to the significant Democratic majority in the balance of the City. Putting most of the Far Northeast into a Bucks County district would make the City more of a one party city and that is not, in my opinion, a net positive for the City.

In addition, based on my own experience when my elected district was divided up, constituents were left wondering whether I represented them or was I representing the "new constituents". The challenges that this split caused staff was significant-they tried to help everyone they were able but with unclear lines of responsibility it was difficult to do the job properly.

The members of the Legislature and this Committee in particular are well aware of the requirements of nearly equal populations and prohibition on discrimination on the basis of race or ethnicity and there is no benefit to reciting the language of the Pennsylvania Supreme Court to you.

In their Opinion on redistricting the Pennsylvania Supreme Court pointed out several principles such as Contiguity, Compactness, Recognition of existing political boundaries and the "Community of Interests" concept. It is my belief that moving large portions of Northeast Philadelphia into a "Buck County" district would sever the Community of Interest that has existed for many years in the Northeast. The residents of Northeast Philadelphia have common economic, social and political interests with one another and Philadelphia as a separate political entity. Dividing the Northeast would be impractical and unfair.

My hope is that the State House will recommend that the Northeast be permitted to retain its essential character and remain part of one Congressional seat with a Philadelphia focus and not Bucks County.

Daniel P. McElhatton, Esquire
2000 Market Street Suite 1400
Philadelphia, PA 19103
215-557-0811
dpmcelhatton@mcfol.com